supergroup, plus one isolated pocket far over to the west, which marks the location of the Brahui language speakers, now entirely surrounded by Baluchi-speakers who form part of the Iranian language group, itself descended from Proto-Indo-Iranian. But what on earth is that pocket doing there, you might well ask, so isolated from the nearest Dravidian-speaking population by more than 800 miles (1300 kilometres)?

There are two possible explanations. One is that this Brahui Dravidian was introduced to that area by immigrants from the South. The other is that Dravidian-based languages were once spoken widely across the Indian subcontinent, only to be supplanted in the North and centre by speakers of Indo-Aryan. There is no evidence in support of the first explanation, whereas there is considerable supporting evidence for the second, not least the number of Dravidian loan words that have been absorbed into Hindi and other Sanskrit-based languages. The map also shows the presence of a third language group of particular relevance here: Austro-Asiatic, the speakers of which are now stuck in small isolated pockets in a sort of no-man's land between the two dominant language groups, mostly in the hill country of central India. These are mainly Munda-speakers, a language now spoken by probably no more than ten million people, so less than 1 per cent of the Indian population. It divides into North Munda, also known as Santali, as spoken in the plateau country of Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh and parts of West Bengal; and South Munda, spoken in the hills of Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. Traces of Munda are also found in a number of mixed languages spoken all the way along the foothills of the Himalayas, all of which points to it being much more widely spoken in South Asia in the distant past, and, in all probability, pre-dating Dravidian.

This, by inference, is the prime language of those often spoken of as *vanavasi*, 'forest people', *girijan*, 'hill people',